

BEYOND THE BASICS: Designing Products For Future Expansion

Building on our series, we journey from axiomatic designs to future-proof product design strategies. In a world of evolving preferences, crafting winning products that command loyalty and premium value hinges on quality, customer affection, and lasting engagement



SOUMYANATH CHATTERJEE is former TVS Motors Chair Professor at Industrial and Systems Engineering Department, IIT Kharagpur. His expertise is in Product Development and Supply Chain Management

In our previous articles, we have delved into the art of creating exceptional products. Yet, in the real world, satisfying customers often calls for more than just one offering. While launching with a single product can minimise initial risk and help us grasp customer expectations, it is essential to evolve. Soon enough, the demand for variety becomes evident as we strive to maintain customer happiness.

But here's the catch: Shaping these fresh variants from scratch comes at a hefty price. Enter the realm of smart design. A skilled designer anticipates future needs and strategically lays the groundwork during the initial creation phase.

So, how do we approach this systematic product design that sets the stage for seamless expansion? Join us as we uncover the strategies to develop products that not only thrive in the present but also pave the way for an exciting future.

Over time, customer preferences and expectations will shift, leading to changes in how they perceive different features. The Kano Model is a tool used to understand customer preferences and prioritise features or attributes of a product or service. This shift in the Kano Model can be understood through three main phases: 'emerging,' 'expected,' and 'basic.'

In the 'emerging' phase, new and innovative features that customers didn't expect are introduced. These features can delight customers and lead to higher satisfaction because they go beyond what customers thought they would receive. However, as time goes on and these fea-

tures become more common, they transition to the 'expected' phase.

In the 'expected' phase, features that were once innovative are now seen as basic requirements. Customers have come to expect them, and their absence can lead to dissatisfaction. These features are no longer a source of delight; instead, they are essential just to meet customer expectations.

Finally, in the 'basic' phase, even features that were once considered expected might become so commonplace that customers no longer pay much attention to them. At this point, these features are taken for granted, and their presence doesn't significantly impact customer satisfaction.

To stay competitive and maintain customer satisfaction, businesses need to continually innovate and introduce new features that can move from the 'emerging' phase to the 'expected' phase. This cycle of shifting preferences highlights the importance of understanding customer needs and staying attuned to changing market dynamics.

There is a tool called the Generational Variety Index (GVI) that helps us to find and predict the parts that are likely to change in our future products. It's like a compass that guides engineers, designers, and innovators as they navigate the complex journey of creating new products.

The GVI is a dynamic tool. As the project progresses and you gather more information, your understanding of the market, technology, and customer needs may evolve. The GVI adapts accordingly,